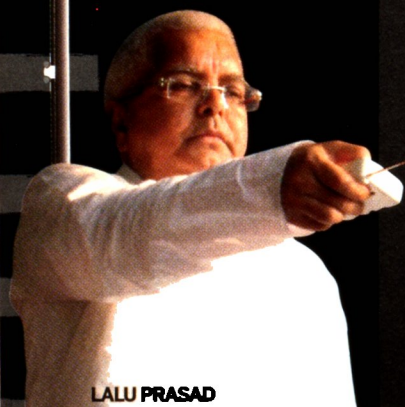


RANJAN RAHI

Bounty for Home



LALU PRASAD

PROJECT AND STATUS

Rs 20-cr concrete sleeper factories at Madhepura and Chak Sikandar

Plants ready for two years but no production

Rs 1,500-cr wheel factory at Chapra

Work near completion by L&T

Rs 70-cr wagon repair shop at Samastipur

Construction underway but location debatable

Rs 70-cr wagon repair shop at Garhara

Construction on but out-of-the-way location

Rs 70-cr wagon repair shop at Garkha

Land acquisition problem

Rs 200-cr coach repair shop at Sonpur

Farmers agitating over land acquisition

PROJECT AND STATUS

Sick Bharat wagon factories taken over at Mokama and Muzaffarpur

Revival plan on with Heavy Industries Ministry

Rs 2,000-cr electric loco factory, Madhepura

Equity-sharing model. No response to tender.

Rs 2,000-cr diesel loco factory, Marhaura

Equity-sharing model. General Electric given tender.

Rs 170-cr takeover of Rohtash Industries

Wagon ancillary unit on SEZ model to be set up

Rs 120-cr super-speciality hospital in Patna

Under construction

Rs 100-cr Bhagalpur and Thawe divisions

Infrastructure for headquarters to come up

Lalu's Bihar EXPRESS

By pushing 300 projects worth Rs 19,000 crore for Bihar, Lalu gets ready for polls

Bubbling with enthusiasm after presenting his first Railway Budget in July 2004, Lalu Prasad promised a "railway job in each house" to a huge roaring crowd in Chapra, his constituency. In fact, it later went on to become his favourite line for his various speeches in Bihar.

Not many believed in his promise at that time. But five years down the line, Lalu would find more takers for his promise. At least after one takes a look at the volume of projects he has gifted Bihar with. Unlike other railway ministers, he has not stopped just at a division or a few trains. Lalu has pushed political will through slothful bureaucracy to have his way.

In five years, Lalu has pushed nearly 300 projects, big and small, worth Rs 19,000 crore which will employ almost 2.5 lakh people in Bihar. Of course, Lalu has had his shares of hurdles, including the omnipresent

Planning Commission, but he managed to navigate his sop engine.

The commission had initially blocked Lalu's proposal for setting up diesel and electric locomotive factories at Marhaura and Madhepura. Lalu had to seek UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi's intervention, after he failed to get support from the PMO, to get the projects cleared.

Similarly, Sonia had also spoken for Lalu on the creation of two new divisions at Bhagalpur and Thawe, which he announced in this interim budget. And for all the troubles, Lalu even bequeathed a return gift to Sonia by sanctioning a Rs 2,200-crore coach factory for Rae Bareilly, her constituency.

It was not just his votebank, Lalu also took care to woo his "home" and in-laws' constituency. Two days before the budget, the railways minister visited Phulwaria, the village where he was born, and assured the people

that more jobs were on the way since he was going to set up a new divisional headquarters there. Phulwaria, in Gopalganj district, is next door to Thawe that got the new division. Lalu, last year, had also laid a 13.5-km railway line at a cost of Rs 60 crore between Phulwaria and Salar Kalan, the birthplace of his wife Rabri Devi.

None of this is accidental. Indeed, after losing Bihar to Nitish Kumar, Lalu realised that if he had to win Bihar he would have to deliver development. He chose the best officers for the state after studying their ACRS. His only directive to all the officers was to speed up work in the state.

As he ended his budget speech, most were blown by his rusticism and poetry. Only those with political insight know that in catering to Bihar he has taken the first steps to consolidate his votebank to enable him to pitch for the top job.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora